society."[1] Others have noted the extraordinary expansion of cultural opportunity, including the literacy campaign and the expansion of schooling at all levels, and the proliferation of cultural institutions like libraries, museums, publishing, theaters, local, regional and national places and spaces for producing and participating in cultural activities – the democratization of culture. Sujatha Fernandes focused on current forms of popular culture like film and rap music, suggesting that "the arts have taken on a vital role in formulating, articulating, and making sense of everyday life."[2] Finally, critics like David Craven and Roberto González Echevarría have examined Cuban artistic production itself under the Revolution, ranging from literature to visual and performance arts.

Virtually everybody who studies culture in Cuba confronts the apparent paradox in revolutionary cultural policies and developments. On one hand, the Revolution has fostered, democratized, and contributed to all areas of culture in ways unprecedented in Latin American history. On the other hand, the Revolution has controlled, censored and restricted cultural production to the extent that numerous authors have chosen exile, and many Cubans complain about the limits on what they can read, listen to, see, or do. Since the advent of the internet, this contradiction may have become even more acute.

Those who have studied Cuban culture also differ as to how much cultural change actually occurred, at the popular level, and to what extent the Revolution succeeded in fostering a vibrant production in the arts. Interestingly, Fagen, who was generally sympathetic to the goals of cultural transformation, saw a significant measure of change in the 1960s; Bunck, writing two decades later and who is quite leery of the goals, believes that little change occurred. What Bunck derides as the imposition of "correct ideological thinking" Fagen describes as a "culture-transforming process."[3]

As of 1985, Bunck argues, "the government's policies had utterly failed to mold Che's 'new man' … Cubans were not thinking and acting as right-minded Marxist-Leninist citizens."[4]